Cornrockets

By Todd Hearon

The scene opens with CHRISTOPHER, a boy of 11, drawing with crayons. He keeps stopping to listen to something only he can hear off stage. Finally, he addresses the audience.

CHRISTOPHER: Hear that? *(gesturing toward noises)* That's me they're making. At it, Harold and Mom. Hopped up, like a couple of rabbits. *(beat)* Like on that battery commercial? The one that never stops? *(proudly shows the picture he's drawing)* That's them. That's these two. They got hopped up a lot.

They don't know, of course, it's me that's coming. Nobody knows, not yet. Least of all ha-ha old Shadowface, working graveyard shift at the prison. Shadowface, he's my—*(beat)* He's "the man Mom's married to." Right now. *(gesturing toward noises)* Get it? While the bunny show is going on. *(sighs)* Ah well. It's as good a way as any to begin.

Anyways, it doesn't matter. Shadowface fades fast. Gets stabbed in the back one night on cell patrol. Next Sunday, Harold shows up at the door. Mom calls me down and says, "Christopher, I'd like for you to meet your father." *(beat)* I say, "But my dad's dead." She smiles, "Well, honey, that's true, too, but this is Harold. Your ***other*** dad. Biological. . ." *(beat)* Biological was a big word for Mom. It meant real. They taught us that in school. As in your "biological father."

"Go on, say hi, polite," Mom says. "Hey," I say. "Hey," says Harold. *(beat)* It was . . . strange.

INTRODUCTION

IN THE PERSONA OF A HOSPITAL ORDERLY: *Christopher was a bright child. Everyone said so. But the death of his father profoundly changed his world. I'm so glad you could come today. Christopher doesn't get many visitors; just the school tutor and his therapist. I know he'll enjoy having a new person to talk to.*

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CHRISTOPHER: Miss Wong, the guidance counselor at school? — all the kids call her Miss Wrong — she says I have a prodigious memory. I had to look it up. **Prodigious**: "enormous or extraordinary in size." She's right, Miss Wong. I remember everything. *(beat)* That's what's wrong. I can't forget.

- I remember the way the sunlight looked on a penny in a puddle one day when I was five.
- Five times seven divided by three is eleven-point-six-repeating.
- I remember the shapes in clouds. The colors. All of them.
- I remember everything I've read. *(quickly)* "The Canyon de Chelly in Arizona is a breathless secret valley which has been inhabited by one Indian tribe after another almost without a break for two thousand years."
- I remember the morning I was born.

The next word down from prodigious in the dictionary is **Prodigy**: "Noun. A person or thing of remarkable qualities or powers." As in "child prodigy." It also can mean monstrous. Most people don't know that. "Something outside of the normal course of nature." *(beat)*

Anyways. Miss Wong says my prodigious memory will come in handy one day, like when I'm an astronaut. That's what I told her I was maybe going to be. An astronaut or a geologist. Her face got bright. "Ah geowogist! Just fink of all dose wocks!" Minerals, actually. *(beat)* Petrologists do rocks. That's when I told her my dream of going to the Grand Canyon — *(he glances offstage as if the sounds are getting louder, then turns back to audience)*

You just have to ignore them. Eventually they go away. It's worse at night. That's not "normal." That's not within "the normal course of nature." *(Silence. He continues to draw)* Us, we never went on family vacation. We went, like everybody else, like to the mall, like Sundays to Lake Michigan, but never technically "on vacation." That's why it was so ultimate the summer I turned ten and Mom said what would I think about a trip—a big trip, the three of us, to—ready? THE GRAND CANYON!

Oh. *(beat)* It was long. Real long and really hot. Middle of July. I rode in the back-back of the station wagon with my stuff. Read a lot. Drew a lot. Stuck to the seat a lot. Watched the

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wires on the side of the highway dip and rise, dip and rise. It was pretty monotonous. ‘Cause Harold drove three days and nights, nonstop. I think he must have been hopped up. I asked why we couldn’t stop and spend the night at a campground, like real vacation families. Harold said this was like being at a campground, just on wheels. *(beat)* It was strange. You wake up moving. *(beat)* I watched our shadow for a long time that first night, in the moonlight, on the side of the road. The three of us, out there, traveling so fast . . . I wondered what we must look like to it, to our shadow. ‘Cause it was just what we were, only not. Our opposite—looking back at us, up from its black, empty world, like us only . . . not . . .

We stopped in the morning for a pee break in this place called Jupiter, Nebraska. I was going to get a postcard for my class — “GREETINGS EARTHLINGS FROM JUPITER NEBRASKA! CORN CAPITAL OF THE UNIVERSE!” Get it? *(beat)* Anyways. That’s when I saw the CornRockets. *(beat)* CornRockets. They’re like — rockets *(beat)* shaped like corn. They’re cool. You take the plug out of the bottom and fill it up with water — that’s the fuel. Then you stick the pump in *(he demonstrates with an imaginary rocket)*, it’s kinda hard, you’ve gotta create a seal. Then you pump it up and pull the latch and — ***whoosh***! Liftoff in a spray of water just like smoke! But the coolest thing is when it hits its apogee — that’s the word for the highest point — an astronaut CornRocketMan pops out and floats off on a parachute. That’s the most righteous thing. Floating off like that. Lost. *(beat)* Harold got pretty pissed about the CornRocketMan getting lost every time we stopped. I said technically he wasn’t “lost” because we always finally found him. “Exactly,” Harold said and took the Man away and put him up on the floorboard, down with all the maps. *(beat)* That was in Colorado, in a place called Glory Falls. *(beat)* I don’t remember seeing any falls.

When we got to the Grand Canyon, it was early Sunday morning. I remember the sun was coming up. The parking lot was empty. Mom looked across at Harold as the car came to a stop and said, “Perfect.” That was my thought, too. Perfect.

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My stomach was full of butterflies as we walked down the hill, towards it. We came to the rail and stepped up, looking out across. I was standing in between them. I could feel their skin. Our arms were touching. *(he steps forward)*

It was every color you remember from the crayon box. Burnt sienna, raw sienna, sepia, raw umber. Far down, a thread of thistle, turquoise blue. Comflower freckles, periwinkle patches on the walls, all Indian red—the whole gone goldenrod in rising sun. Maize. Amazing. Earth. But not Earth. The opposite of Earth, Earth's . . . shadow? Space where Earth had been, before a giant's hand scooped it out. Now, bright big bowl of morning air. And the colors—all down the walls, I named them but I couldn't see how deep. I leaned across the rail and balanced on my buckle and, swear, for a second I was flying. Out and out—not a bird, not a plane, but *(beat)* SuperCornRocketChristopher! AstroGeologistMan! And down, down, down, parachuting through, I memorized the colors on the walls. Every patch, each stranded tuft of tree. Birds, this big — I was looking at the backs of flying birds! I turned to Mom and Harold — "Look! it's—" *(pause)* Gone.

I got down off the rail and walked back up the hill. I was coming to the car when I heard it. That sound. They were at it, somewhere. The information booth? The bathrooms? The cactus patch? Wherever. *(sighs)* I walked up to the car to wait. That's when I saw the windows were rolled down. There they were, in the back-back. Hopped up, going at it, all over my stuff. They didn't see me; I saw them. *(beat)* It wasn't normal.

I walked around to the driver's side. I looked up at the sun. It had come a long way, from the opposite side of the world. China . . . I thought of Miss Wong. I thought of all the other kids in my class. I watched them for a while.

My ComRocketMan was down where Harold kept him, on the floorboard, down with all the maps. I reached in through the window. It was louder inside. *(his movements are hurried, frenetic)* I see him, down there. Past the brake. The handle says "EMERGENCY." I'm trying to be quick, but the Man, the Man, he catches on the handle as I pull. *(beat)* It pops. The

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wagon starts to roll. *(he crouches and begins to mime the action of priming a CornRocket. He is speaking quickly, forcefully, as if to block out the sounds]*

Pull plug, fill rocket hull with fuel, replace plug, five times seven divided by three, take pump, in Arizona is a breathless, insert pump, a secret canyon, screw, inhabited, create a seal, almost without a break for, pump, two thousand years, eleven, pump, point six repeating, five, pump four, repeating, pump, for three, two, one, pull!—

(CHRISTOPHER looks up. No SOUND)

I was flying. This was our vacation. The three of us, a family, standing at the rail. One morning, for a morning, it was real. For just one second it was biological. We could have been a postcard. I could have stuck a stamp on us and sent us back to school: "GREETINGS EARTHLINGS FROM CHRIS T. ON VACATION! This is my family. Look at us and weep." That's the memory I wanted—the one, us three, that Sunday morning speechless at the rail. Perfect, like she said. Above the empty Earth. The opposite of shadow. Real. *(he looks down in his empty hands. Silence)*

I fired the CornRocket after them over the edge. And as it hit its apogee, I saw the astronaut eject and disappear. Parachuting down that maze of morning light. Lost.

(Silence)

I wish I'd never been.

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